CHAPTER 68 National Disaster Management Authority

Establishment

The Government of India, recognising the importance of disaster management as a national priority, had set up a High Powered Committee in 1999 and a National Committee in 2001 after the Gujarat earthquake, to make recommendations on the preparation of disaster management plans and suggest effective mitigation mechanisms. However, after the Indian Ocean tsunami of 2004, the Government of India took a defining step in the legislative history of the country by enacting the Disaster Management Act, 2005[1].

The Act provided for the creation of the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) to spearhead and implement a holistic and integrated approach to disaster management in the country. Initially, the NDMA was constituted in 2005 by an Executive Order of the Government of India. Subsequently, the NDMA was notified in 2006 under the provisions of the Act[2].

The NDMA consists of a chairperson and other members, not exceeding nine. The Prime Minister is the ex-officio chairperson of the NDMA. The other members are nominated by the chairperson of the NDMA. The chairperson of the NDMA designates one of the members as the vice-chairperson of the NDMA. The vice-chairperson has the status of a Cabinet Minister while the other members have the status of a Minister of State.

The NDMA is the apex body for disaster management in the country. It works under the administrative control of the Union Ministry of Home Affairs.

The NDMA was established with this vision: 'To build a safer and disaster resilient India by a holistic, pro-active, technology driven and sustainable development strategy that involves all stakeholders and fosters a culture of prevention, preparedness and mitigation'.

Objectives

The objectives of the NDMA are as follows[3]:

1. To promote a culture of prevention, preparedness and resilience at all levels through knowledge, innovation and education.
2. To encourage mitigation measures based on technology, traditional wisdom and environmental sustainability.
3. To mainstream disaster management into the developmental planning process.
4. To establish institutional and techno-legal frameworks to create an enabling regulatory environment and a compliance regime.
5. To ensure an efficient mechanism for identification, assessment and monitoring of disaster risks.
6. To develop contemporary forecasting and early warning systems backed by responsive and failsafe communication with information technology support.